# Time & effort

A conversational idiom workbook: 9 phrases, each with a short conversation and four quick tasks. Do it online and check your answers, or print it and use the answer key at the end.

## In this workbook

1. **easy peasy, lemon squeezy**: Very, very easy. It is a playful, rhyming phrase.
2. **faff about**: To waste time doing small, unimportant things instead of getting on with a task.
3. **fall by the wayside**: To stop being done or looked after because other things became more important.
4. **get caught up in**: To get caught up in something is to become so busy with it that you forget other things.
5. **give or take**: 'Give or take' means about, with a small amount more or less.
6. **go to town**: To do something with great energy and enthusiasm, without holding back.
7. **lose sight of**: To forget or stop thinking about what is most important.
8. **not just yet**: Not now, but maybe soon.
9. **run out of time**: To have no time left; to use all your time.

**How to use it:** read the conversation out loud first, then do the four tasks. For the last task, answer out loud before you write, and try to use the phrase naturally.

# easy peasy, lemon squeezy

Idiom | Level B1 | Casual

Very, very easy. It is a playful, rhyming phrase.

**Tip:** Use it after 'was/is/it's' to describe a task that turned out simple; it sounds playful and cheerful, so save it for friendly chats rather than serious or formal situations.

**Olena:** Did you manage to book the train tickets for Saturday?

**Kofi:** Yes, all done. I was worried about the booking site, but it was easy peasy, lemon squeezy.

**Olena:** Really? Last time it kept crashing on me.

**Kofi:** It took about three minutes. I even picked our seats.

**Olena:** Great, then I'll let you book the hotel too.

### 1. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does easy peasy, lemon squeezy mean?

- ○ A. Cheap, so it didn't cost much money
- ○ B. Surprisingly pleasant, even though it was difficult
- ○ C. Very simple to do, with no trouble at all
- ○ D. Quick, but not done very carefully

### 2. Fill the gap

I thought the form would take hours, but it was _____ .

### 3. Choose the best reply

**Amira:** *How did you find the driving test? Was it stressful?*

- ○ A. I'm sorry, I'll be easy peasy, lemon squeezy and try again next month.
- ○ B. Not at all. Parking was easy peasy, lemon squeezy, and the roads were quiet.
- ○ C. Yes, it was easy peasy, lemon squeezy, so I felt very nervous the whole time.

### 4. Your turn: speak

Tell me about something you learned to do recently that turned out to be simpler than you expected.

_____

_____

_____

# faff about

Phrasal verb | Level C1 | Casual

To waste time doing small, unimportant things instead of getting on with a task.

**Tip:** Use 'faff about' (or 'faff around') for wasting time on small things, often with 'instead of' + -ing; it's informal and sounds a little impatient, so avoid it in formal writing.

**Olena:** Have you sent the booking form yet? The deadline is at five.

**Kofi:** Not yet. I spent the morning faffing about with the font and the colours.

**Olena:** Kofi, nobody will care what it looks like. They just need the dates.

**Kofi:** You're right. I'll fill in the details now and send it in ten minutes.

**Olena:** Good. Message me when it's done and I'll double-check it.

### 5. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "faffing about" mean?

- ○ A. Working very carefully to make sure everything is perfect
- ○ B. Forgetting to do something that was important
- ○ C. Spending time on small, unimportant things instead of the main task
- ○ D. Asking other people for help with a difficult task

### 6. Fill the gap

I meant to start my essay at nine, but I ended up _____ with my desk and my playlist for an hour.

### 7. Choose the best reply

**Amira:** *We've got a train in twenty minutes and you still haven't packed your bag!*

- ○ A. Yes, I'm faffing about it now so we'll be early.
- ○ B. Sorry, I know. I've been faffing about on my phone instead of getting ready.
- ○ C. Don't worry, I faffed about my bag very quickly last night.

### 8. Your turn: speak

Do you ever find it hard to start a task you need to finish? Tell me about a time when this happened.

_____

_____

_____

# fall by the wayside

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

To stop being done or looked after because other things became more important.

**Tip:** Use it about habits, plans or tasks that get neglected over time, usually without anyone deciding to stop; the subject is the thing that was dropped ("my gym routine fell by the wayside"), not the person.

**Ken:** Are you still doing those Spanish lessons on your phone every morning?

**Olena:** Honestly, no. They fell by the wayside once the project at work got busy.

**Ken:** That happens to me all the time. I get a streak going and then one hectic week ruins it.

**Olena:** Exactly. I keep telling myself I'll start again on Monday.

**Ken:** Try ten minutes on the train. That's easy to keep up.

**9. What does it mean?**

In this conversation, what does "fell by the wayside" mean?

- ○ A. Had to be done in a different place
- ○ B. Became too difficult to understand
- ○ C. Stopped happening because other things took priority
- ○ D. Was cancelled by the company on purpose

**10. Fill the gap**

With three kids and a new house, a lot of his hobbies have _____ .

**11. Choose the best reply**

**Amira:** *You used to cook so much. Do you still make everything from scratch?*

- ○ A. Not really. I fell by the wayside my dinner when I came home.
- ○ B. Yes, I always fall by the wayside on Sundays to make big meals.
- ○ C. Not really. Since I started working late, cooking has fallen by the wayside.

**12. Your turn: speak**

Tell me about a habit or activity you used to do regularly but stopped. What happened?

_____

_____

_____

# get caught up in

Phrasal verb | Level B2 | Neutral

To get caught up in something is to become so busy with it that you forget other things.

**Tip:** Use it with 'in' plus a noun or -ing form (get caught up in a conversation / in planning the trip); it often explains why you lost track of time or forgot something, and don't confuse it with 'be caught' meaning trapped or arrested.

**Amira:** Ken, I waited for you at the station for twenty minutes. Where were you?

**Ken:** I'm so sorry! I got caught up in a work call and completely lost track of time.

**Amira:** I wish you'd texted me. I thought something had happened.

**Ken:** You're right. My phone was on silent, too. Have you eaten?

**Amira:** Not yet. Let's just go to that noodle place by the exit.

**13. What does it mean?**

In this conversation, what does 'got caught up in' mean?

- ○ A. Finally finished a task that he had been avoiding
- ○ B. Was angry or upset about something that happened at work
- ○ C. Was delayed because a train or bus was cancelled
- ○ D. Became so involved in something that he forgot about other things

**14. Fill the gap**

Olena meant to leave the library at five, but she _____ her essay and stayed until it closed.

**15. Choose the best reply**

**Diego:** *You still haven't replied to my message from this morning!*

- ○ A. Sorry, I caught up in a few meetings and forgot all about it.
- ○ B. Sorry, I got caught up in a few meetings and forgot all about it.
- ○ C. Sorry, my meetings got caught up me and I forgot all about it.

**16. Your turn: speak**

Tell me about a time when you lost track of time because you were busy with something.

_____

_____

_____

# give or take

Expression · Level B2 · Neutral

'Give or take' means about, with a small amount more or less.

**Tip:** Put it after a number or amount, usually at the end of the phrase: 'twenty people, give or take'. Use it for estimates, not for exact facts.

**Olena:** How many people are coming to the housewarming on Saturday?

**Kofi:** Thirty, give or take. A few haven't replied yet.

**Olena:** Okay. Do we have enough chairs for that?

**Kofi:** We have about twenty-five, so I'll ask the neighbours to lend us some.

**Olena:** Good idea. I'll make sure there's plenty of food too.

### 17. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'give or take' mean?

- ○ A. About that number, but it could be a little more or less
- ○ B. Thirty people who will give something to the party
- ○ C. Exactly thirty, with no changes
- ○ D. At least thirty, and probably many more

### 18. Fill the gap

The meeting should finish at four o'clock, _____ ten minutes.

### 19. Choose the best reply

**Amira:** *How long have you been working at the company?*

- ○ A. I give or take six years at the company.
- ○ B. Six years, give or take. I started in the spring.
- ○ C. Give or take, I worked there for exactly six years and two days.

### 20. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a journey you often make. How long does it usually take?

# go to town

Idiom · Level B2 · Casual

To do something with great energy and enthusiasm, without holding back.

**Tip:** Use it as 'go to town on/with something' or 'go to town doing something'; it's informal, usually positive, and describes enthusiastic effort rather than literally travelling.

**Olena:** Your flat looks amazing! Did you hire someone to do the garden?

**Diego:** No, I did it all myself over the weekend. Once I started, I really went to town.

**Olena:** I can tell. Where did all those lights and flower pots come from?

**Diego:** The garden centre had a sale, so I bought way more than I needed.

**Olena:** Well, it was worth it. It looks like a little café out there.

**21. What does it mean?**

In this conversation, what does "went to town" mean?

- ○ A. Finished the job quickly so he could relax
- ○ B. Travelled to the town centre to buy supplies
- ○ C. Put in a lot of energy and effort, holding nothing back
- ○ D. Asked for help because the job was too big

**22. Fill the gap**

Ken usually keeps his emails short, but this time he _____ and wrote five pages about the new schedule.

**23. Choose the best reply**

**Kofi:** *I told Amira she could choose the playlist for the party, and she's made one that's six hours long!*

- ○ A. Yes, she went to town and didn't come back.
- ○ B. Wow, she really went to town on it!
- ○ C. Well, she went to town to find some speakers.

**24. Your turn: speak**

Tell me about a time you put a lot of effort into a project or a celebration.

# lose sight of

Expression | Level B2 | Neutral

To forget or stop thinking about what is most important.

**Tip:** Use it as lose sight of + noun (lose sight of the goal, the big picture, what matters); it often follows 'don't' or 'easy to' and works in both casual and formal speech.

**Olena:** You look exhausted, Kofi. Are you still working on the kitchen yourself?

**Kofi:** Yes, and I'm spending hours choosing between two almost identical shades of white paint.

**Olena:** Be careful you don't lose sight of why you started. You wanted a bright, simple room.

**Kofi:** You're right. Honestly, either colour would look fine.

**Olena:** Then pick one tonight and start painting tomorrow.

**25. What does it mean?**

In this conversation, what does "lose sight of" mean?

- ○ A. Lose something you were carrying
- ○ B. Be unable to see something because it is too far away
- ○ C. Forget or stop focusing on what really matters
- ○ D. Stop liking something you used to enjoy

**26. Fill the gap**

When a project gets stressful, it's easy to _____ the reason you chose it in the first place.

**27. Choose the best reply**

**Ken:** *I've been checking my savings app every hour, and now I'm too stressed to enjoy my trip planning.*

- ○ A. Try not to lose sight of the point. This trip is supposed to be fun.
- ○ B. I lost sight of you at the airport, so I'm not surprised.
- ○ C. Yes, you should lose sight of your savings app and look at the mountains.

**28. Your turn: speak**

Tell me about a time when you were so busy with small details that you forgot what was really important.

# not just yet

Expression | Level B1 | Casual

Not now, but maybe soon.

**Tip:** Use it as a short reply when someone asks if you're ready or if something can start; it often comes before a reason, and 'just yet' makes the delay feel brief.

**Olena:** Hey Kofi, are you ready to leave? The taxi's outside.

**Kofi:** Not just yet. I can't find my charger.

**Olena:** Is it in your bag?

**Kofi:** I checked there. Oh, wait, it's under the sofa. Got it!

**Olena:** Great. Two minutes, then we go?

**Kofi:** Two minutes. I just need to grab my coat.

### 29. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "Not just yet" mean?

- ○ A. He isn't ready now, but he will be soon.
- ○ B. He has already left.
- ○ C. He doesn't want to leave at all.
- ○ D. He is only ready to leave a little.

### 30. Fill the gap

Has the meeting started? _____ , we're still waiting for two people.

### 31. Choose the best reply

**Amira:** *Are you finished with the report? Can I read it?*

- ○ A. Not just yet. I need to check the numbers first.
- ○ B. Just not yet. It is always ready for you.
- ○ C. Not just yet. I finished it yesterday, so here it is.

### 32. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you weren't ready to do something, but you planned to do it soon.

_____

_____

_____

# run out of time

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Neutral

To have no time left; to use all your time.

**Tip:** Use 'run out of time' (no object) to say the time is finished, and 'run out of + noun' for other things (run out of money, run out of milk); don't confuse it with 'be out of time', which sounds more final.

**Olena:** How did the presentation go this morning?

**Ken:** Not great, honestly. I spent too long on the first few slides.

**Olena:** Oh no. Did you get to the end?

**Ken:** Not really. I ran out of time before I could show the results.

**Olena:** That's a shame, those were the best part. Maybe you can send them by email.

**Ken:** Good idea. I'll do that after lunch.

**33. What does it mean?**

In this conversation, what does 'ran out of time' mean?

- ○ A. He had no time left to finish what he wanted to do.
- ○ B. He arrived late for the presentation.
- ○ C. He left the room because he was nervous.
- ○ D. He forgot to prepare the slides.

**34. Fill the gap**

I wanted to check my answers again, but I _____ before the exam ended.

**35. Choose the best reply**

**Amira:** *Did you finish the whole report before the meeting?*

- ○ A. Almost. I ran out of the report, so the last page is still empty.
- ○ B. Almost. I ran out of time, so the last page is still empty.
- ○ C. Almost. The meeting ran out of me, so the last page is still empty.

**36. Your turn: speak**

Tell me about a time when you didn't have enough time to finish something. What happened?

_____

_____

_____

# Answer key

**easy peasy, lemon squeezy**

1. C. Very simple to do, with no trouble at all
2. easy peasy, lemon squeezy
3. B. Not at all. Parking was easy peasy, lemon squeezy, and the roads were quiet.
4. Example: Last month I learned how to make bread at home. I thought it would be complicated, but with a good recipe it was easy peasy, lemon squeezy. Now I bake a loaf almost every weekend.

**faff about**

5. C. Spending time on small, unimportant things instead of the main task
6. faffing about
7. B. Sorry, I know. I've been faffing about on my phone instead of getting ready.
8. Example: Yes, definitely. Last month I had a big report to write, but I kept faffing about, tidying my files and checking messages instead of actually starting. In the end I had to turn off my phone and work late to finish it.

**fall by the wayside**

9. C. Stopped happening because other things took priority
10. fallen by the wayside
11. C. Not really. Since I started working late, cooking has fallen by the wayside.
12. Example: I used to go swimming every week before work. When my schedule changed and I started leaving home earlier, it fell by the wayside. I'd like to get back to it, but I haven't found the time yet.

**get caught up in**

13. D. Became so involved in something that he forgot about other things
14. got caught up in
15. B. Sorry, I got caught up in a few meetings and forgot all about it.
16. Example: Last weekend I started tidying my bookshelf, and I got caught up in sorting old photos I found. Before I knew it, three hours had passed and I'd missed lunch. It was fun, though, so I didn't mind.

**give or take**

17. A. About that number, but it could be a little more or less
18. give or take
19. B. Six years, give or take. I started in the spring.
20. Example: I take the bus to work every day, and it usually takes forty minutes, give or take. If the traffic is bad, it can be a bit longer. I like the time because I can read or listen to music.

**go to town**

21. C. Put in a lot of energy and effort, holding nothing back
22. went to town
23. B. Wow, she really went to town on it!
24. Example: Last year I organised a surprise birthday party for my sister, and I really went to town. I made decorations by hand, cooked for twenty people and even created a photo slideshow. It was exhausting, but seeing her face made it all worthwhile.

**lose sight of**

25. C. Forget or stop focusing on what really matters
26. lose sight of

27. A. Try not to lose sight of the point. This trip is supposed to be fun.
28. Example: Last year I organised a surprise party for my sister, and I spent weeks worrying about the decorations and the playlist. Eventually I realised I had lost sight of the main thing, which was simply to make her feel special. After that, I relaxed, kept it simple, and she loved it.

**not just yet**

29. A. He isn't ready now, but he will be soon.
30. Not just yet
31. A. Not just yet. I need to check the numbers first.
32. Example: Last month my friends asked if I wanted to join a gym. I said, 'Not just yet,' because I wanted to finish a busy project at work first. Two weeks later, I signed up and I've been going ever since.

**run out of time**

33. A. He had no time left to finish what he wanted to do.
34. ran out of time
35. B. Almost. I ran out of time, so the last page is still empty.
36. Example: Last month I was packing for a trip and I left everything until the final evening. I ran out of time and forgot to pack my charger, so I had to buy a new one at the airport. Now I always start packing a day earlier.